MARYLEBONE ROSTER · LINKS DESIGNER · THE SHORTLIST



Three good links, one edge each

Even Step, Common Ground and Short Run, against each other and against today's link

Prepared 5 Nov 2026 · every figure is computed from the rotas

What all three share

Eighteen designs are in the pack; these three were shortlisted on 5 Nov 2026, and page 2 says why. Everything below holds for all three, each line better than or level with today; what is worse than today is on page 2.

✔ All **9 of 9** December staffing rules (today 4), and all three flexible ones: 14 on a Saturday, evenly spaced cover weeks, weekday closers from 15:45

✔ **About 14 full weekends off a year** (today 10), 7 in 26, never more than 5 weeks apart (today up to 7 apart)

✔ Every closing shift **shorter, by 30 minutes to an hour** — the weekday's and Sunday's 8h 10m on all three (today 8h 40m and 8h 55m); no shift over 9h 00m

✔ **No avoidable fatigue warning**, cover weeks aside; one if a cover week falls badly — over 55 hours in seven days. Never more than **five days in a row**, cover weeks aside; seven if a cover week falls badly (today 4 warnings, up to 5; seven days, up to nine)

✔ The same **35-hour** week and **218.6 days** a year, under the ceiling of 219 (today 219.0)

✔ **Every working week all earlies or all lates**, none mixing the two (today 7 of 16 mix them)

Where they differ

the better of the three on each line in bold green; today for scale, not ranked

MEASURE	TODAY	EVEN STEP	COMMON GROUND	SHORT RUN
Heaviest week, Mon–Sat	43h 50m	**41h 30m**	42h 30m	42h 30m
Lightest week, Mon–Sat	25h 10m	**25h 30m**	**25h 30m**	24h 30m
Shortest rest, fixed duties	12h 30m	**14h 35m**	**14h 35m**	14h 20m
Closing shift, Saturday	9h 10m	**8h 10m**	**8h 10m**	8h 40m
Earlies over 8h 30m, Mon–Sat, each a year	0	**0**	**0**	20
Any shift over 8h 30m, Mon–Sat, each a year	31	**0**	4	26
Earlies finishing before 14:00, each a year	26	10	**12**	0
Weekday lates, closers aside, on average	8h 30m	8h 27m	8h 30m	**8h 00m**
Weeks on one shift time, Mon–Fri	7 of 16	18 of 21	**19 of 21**	18 of 21
Week-to-week change of start	4h 00m	1h 31m	**1h 12m**	1h 13m
Shift times, and how many are new	18 (0 new)	**13 (5 new)**	14 (7 new)	15 (6 new)
New shift times on a Saturday	0	1	3	**0**
Single rest days, each a year	10	**8**	12	**8**
Days off 14 days' leave buys at best · leave for four weeks off	30 · 14	28 · 15	**30** · **14**	28 · 15
Fit to the trains, weekday · Sat · Sun (0 = exact)	52.0 · 65.9 · 71.7	32.6 · **10.0** · 29.0	32.7 · 11.2 · **28.2**	**29.1** · 12.7 · 29.0

Each one's edge

★ recommended

Even Step ES-26-T5 · d1921b7a

No long days, Monday to Saturday. No shift there over 8h 30m and every early one of today's times; today's 13:45 every weekday, the fewest shift times of the three, 13, and the steadiest weeks. Its cost: the biggest change of start, 1h 31m, and 15 days' leave for four weeks off.

Common Ground CG-26-T8 · e02c295f

Today's leave. 14 days buy 30 days off at best and four weeks off take 14, as today; one shift time Monday to Friday in 19 of 21 weeks, the gentlest change of start and the closest Sunday fit (28.2). Its cost: 12 single rest days a year, not 8, the weakest weekday fit (32.7), four at the open, seven new times, a 9-hour Saturday late.

Short Run SR-26-F1 · 618348d6

The closest weekday fit, the shortest weekday lates. 29.1 against 32.6 and 32.7, weekday lates of 8h 00m on average, and nothing new on a Saturday. Its cost: an 8h 40m Saturday closer, 14h 20m the shortest rest, no early finish before 14:00, 20 earlies a year over 8h 30m, all 9h 00m, and four weeks off for 15 days' leave.

Which one, by what matters most

IF THE MAIN PRIORITY IS	CHOOSE
Of these three, no shift over 8h 30m from Monday to Saturday	**Even Step**
Of these three, today's leave: 30 days off for 14 days' leave, four weeks for 14	**Common Ground**
Of these three, the closest weekday fit and the shortest weekday lates	**Short Run**
OUTSIDE THE SHORTLIST	
A 16:00 closer Monday to Saturday, shorter than the three's	**Closing Time** · Both Ways too
No shift over 8h 30m on any day, Sunday included	**Fair Share** · Grand Tour too
The fewest new shift times: two	**Home Grown**
A fourth person to the Saturday close	**Even Keel** · Fine Tune too
The steadiest start times from week to week	**Second Edition**

THE SHORTLIST · CONTINUED

Against today, and a recommendation

On most of what a colleague feels the three are the same — a figure in grey is shared by all three

Against today's link

a year: the rotation's count scaled to 52 weeks; days a year and full weekends off on page 1, the leave below

MEASURE	TODAY	EVEN STEP	COMMON GROUND	SHORT RUN
Saturdays a year, each	26	28	28	28
Sunday overtime duties a year, each	21	20	20	20
Starting at 06:20, each a year	62	60	48	60
Average shift, Mon–Sat	8h 14m	8h 16m	8h 16m	8h 16m

Why these three and not the other fifteen

Shortlisted on 5 Nov 2026: Even Step, first in the pack's league; Common Ground, as the example of the links that keep today's leave; Short Run, which colleagues have seen. Each other design keeps something, and pays for it:

In Step	steadier weeks and a closer Saturday fit — but the most long earlies, 40 a year each
Closing Time	shorter closers and a closer Saturday fit — but fewer weeks on one turn and a weaker weekday fit
Both Ways	shorter closers and more early finishes — but fewer weeks on one turn and more long shifts
Home Grown	the fewest shift times and new times — but today's 9h 10m Saturday closer and a weaker fit
Even Keel, Fine Tune	four at the Saturday close — but weeks mixing earlies and lates, and longer blocks
Second Edition	the steadiest start times from week to week — but six days in a row, cover weeks aside
Second Look	no 55-hour week at all — but six days in a row and fewer weeks on one turn
Clean Slate	the best weekend fit of all — but ten new times, four on a Saturday
Next Step	Even Step with a closer weekday fit and a gentler change of start — but one more new time
Fair Share	Next Step with an even Sunday and no shift over 8h 30m — but a weaker Sunday fit and a new time
Grand Tour	today's leave and no shift over 8h 30m on any day — but fewer weeks on one turn
Open Return, Short Openers	today's leave and no 55-hour week — but a 13h 15m shortest rest and more long shifts
Long Break	Common Ground's four weeks for 14 days' leave and fewer single rest days — but six days in a row

The honest costs, against today

- **Late finishes.** 42 a year each at 23:00 or later (today 39) and 94 at 22:00 or later (today 78) on all three. Three to the close every day, where today has two Monday to Saturday, means no link meeting the rules has fewer than 42 at 23:00 or later.
- **Longer blocks.** Up to 5 weeks of earlies or of lates in a row on all three, 7 with cover weeks beside them (today 2, up to 3).
- **Fewer long breaks.** Today five of its 17 rest-day breaks are three or four days, about 13 a year each; Common Ground has two, of three days, about 4 a year each, and the other two none.
- **Early finishes.** Fewer before 14:00 than today's 26 a year each: 10 on Even Step, 12 on Common Ground, none on Short Run.
- **Leave, on Even Step and Short Run.** 14 days' leave buys at best 28 days off, not today's 30, and four complete weeks off in a row, Sunday to Saturday, take 15 days' leave, not 14 — the two that people plan a year around. Common Ground keeps today's, for 12 single rest days a year, not 8. At worst 14 days buys 20 days off on all three, a day more than today's 19.
- **Saturdays.** About 2 more a year on all three (28, today 26): fourteen on a Saturday across 26 lines, today ten across 20.
- **New times.** 5 of Even Step's 13 shift times are new, 7 of Common Ground's 14, 6 of Short Run's 15: shorter versions of today's lates on each (three, three and four), and besides, a 12:15–20:30 and a 9-hour Sunday early on Even Step; a 07:00–15:30 early, the 9-hour Saturday late and two Sunday earlies on Common Ground; a longer weekday early and the Sunday early on Short Run.

Recommendation

Even Step. Alone of the three, no shift over 8h 30m Monday to Saturday (Common Ground 4 a year each, Short Run 26, today 31), and every early there one of today's times; the 13:45 stays every weekday. The fewest shift times, 13 with 5 new, the steadiest weeks (25h 30m to 41h 30m) and the closest Saturday fit (10.0); with Common Ground, the 14h 35m rest and 8h 10m Saturday closer; with Short Run, 8 single rest days a year, not 12. Days in a row, weekends and late finishes as both. Between the other two: weekday lates (8h 27m), early finishes (10 a year), weekday fit (32.6) and new Saturday times (one). Its costs: the biggest change of start, 1h 31m (Common Ground 1h 12m, Short Run 1h 13m); and, as on Short Run, 18 of 21 weeks on one shift time, a 29.0 Sunday fit and four weeks off for 15 days' leave, 28 days at best, where Common Ground has 19, 28.2 and today's 14 and 30.

But it is a judgement. In the pack's weighted league (the owner's weights) Even Step is first, on 85.5, under half a point ahead of Next Step, Closing Time and Fair Share; Short Run is twelfth. Of the links keeping today's leave, Grand Tour scores 83.9 and Common Ground 83.7. Weighted as before 31 Oct, Even Step was second, behind In Step. So choose by what matters here:

- **Choose Even Step** if avoiding long days, Monday to Saturday, matters most — for a 1h 31m change of start and four weeks off for 15 days' leave.
- **Choose Common Ground** if keeping today's leave matters most — for 12 single rest days a year, a weaker weekday fit, four at the open and seven new shift times.
- **Choose Short Run** if the weekday fit and short weekday lates matter most — for an 8h 40m Saturday closer, no 13:45, 20 earlies a year each over 8h 30m and four weeks off for 15 days' leave.